

Commentary on the Praise of Infinite Qualities

Guṇāparyantastotraṭīkā · Toh 1156 · Derge Tengyur

ཡན་ཏན་མཐའ་ཡས་པར་བསྐྱོད་པའི་འགྲེལ་པ

The Commentary on the Praise of Infinite Qualities, in Sanskrit Guṇāparyantastotraṭīkā and in Tibetan Yönten Tayepar Töpé Drelpa, is a brief Indian commentary that its colophon attributes to the great master Dignāga. It explains a hymn of praise to the Buddha, the Praise of Infinite Qualities, by mapping the hymn's verses onto the stages of the Buddha's career: the phase of the cause, from the first resolve for awakening through the practice of the perfections to the exercise of mastery; the phase of the result, his awakening; and the phase of acting for the benefit of beings, beginning with his turning of the wheel of Dharma. Across six short chapters it identifies each verse of the hymn by its opening words and names the point that verse teaches, closing with the dedication of merit. It is Toh 1156 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: guṇa aparyanta stotra ṭīkā

In the language of Tibet: Commentary on the Praise of Infinite Qualities

Homage to the noble Mañjuśrī.

This introductory verse, the one beginning "The bounds of the Victor's qualities are not known," teaches these four summary points: not fully knowing the qualities, being free of exaggeration, being free of pride, and accomplishing the desired aim. Of these, the first words teach not fully knowing the qualities. The words "Since, even though these beings have offered you praise" show the absence of exaggeration. The words "though very small" show the absence of pride. The words "For this purpose, though my understanding is very small, I strive" teach accomplishing the desired aim.

Then the praise is composed in fifty verses, beginning with "Even while dwelling in the lower realms." Praise, here, is that which declares uncommon qualities. It is, moreover, endowed with three phases: the phase of the cause, the phase of the result, and the phase of acting for the benefit of sentient beings. Of these, the phase of the cause extends from generating the mind of awakening and so forth up to sitting at the seat of awakening. The phase of the result is the generation of the gnosis of perfect and complete awakening, the phase in which all faults have been abandoned and all qualities attained. The phase of acting for the benefit of sentient beings extends from the

teaching, the turning of the wheel of Dharma and so forth, up until that teaching comes to its disappearance.

Of these, the phase of the cause comprises the phase of intention, the phase of application, and the phase of mastery. The phase of intention is the aspiration through which one comes to engage in benefiting others. It is further illustrated in four ways: reflection on the suffering produced, reflection on the help rendered, reflection on the companionship given, and reflection on what has been fully enjoyed. That aspiration for awakening has four causes, those spoken of in these lines:

Spiritual lineage, a virtuous friend, compassion,
And not being turned back by sufferings:
Through these, the four causes and conditions,
One fully enters the mind of awakening.

Thus intention is taught through ten points.

Here, the verse beginning "Even while dwelling in the lower realms" teaches the aspiration that turns toward the benefit of others. Its close reflections are four. First, the verse beginning "Toward sentient beings wounded by sufferings" is the reflection on the suffering produced. The verse beginning "Blinded by ignorance" is the reflection on the help rendered. The verse beginning "Formerly, in saṃsāra" is the reflection on the companionship given. The verse beginning "Considering enjoyments past" is the reflection on what has been fully enjoyed. The verse beginning "Since beings have not passed beyond sorrow" is the aspiration for awakening. Its causes, too, are of four kinds. Of these, first, the verse beginning "In lowly states" concerns having the spiritual lineage. The verse beginning "Since, if it depended on oneself" concerns reliance on a virtuous friend. The verse beginning "The river of afflictions surging wildly" concerns compassion. The verse beginning "These people of the world, even toward themselves" concerns not being turned back by suffering. Thus ten points are taught by ten verses.

The first chapter, on the phase of intention.

What is called the phase of application is, moreover, all that teaches the perfections. It is of two kinds: that of those who practice through conviction, and that of those who have attained the grounds. Of these, first, the perfections of those who practice through conviction are ten, namely the perfections of generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, wisdom, skillful means, aspiration, power, and gnosis.

Of these, the verse beginning "Who, even on seeing lowly and destitute people with hopeful minds" teaches the perfection of generosity. The verse beginning "Though speaking words endowed with reason" teaches the perfection of moral discipline. The verse beginning "Since even the nonvirtuous actions of the wise" teaches the perfection of patience by way of abandoning what opposes it. The verse beginning "In order to bring oneself to peace" teaches the perfection of diligence. The verse beginning "You did not forsake your wish to give" teaches the perfection of meditative concentration by way of abandoning what opposes it. The verse beginning "You did not praise yourself" teaches the perfection of wisdom by way of abandoning what opposes it. The verse beginning "Out of weariness with existence and the afflictions," together with the verse beginning "Wisdom and the other qualities": these two verses teach the perfection of skillful means in the form of an objection and its reply. The verse beginning "Never at any time did it occur" teaches the perfection of aspiration, through which excellence comes to completion. The verse beginning "The autumn moon at night" teaches the perfection of power. The verse beginning "When the world is wounded by sufferings" teaches the perfection of gnosis.

The second chapter, on the phase of application of those who practice through conviction.

The generosity of those who have attained the grounds is endowed with four complete excellences: excellence of intention, excellence of application, excellence of the recipient, and excellence of what is given. The verse beginning "Rich and prosperous" shows the excellence of intention. The verse beginning "Without eagerness to give" shows the excellence of application. The verse beginning "Like birds to the trees of ripened fruit on mountain slopes" shows the excellence of the recipient. The verse beginning "Riches, subjects, and queens" shows the excellence of what is given; this is the perfection of generosity. The verse beginning "Harm arises for this world" shows the perfection of moral discipline, completely pure in its intrinsic nature. The verse beginning "Just as a physician toward one in the grip of a seizing spirit" shows the perfection of patience free of conceptual thought. The verse beginning "You, ever reverent toward those of surpassing wealth in good qualities" shows the perfection of diligence enhanced by skillful means.

The verse beginning "Just as a nurse her own body" teaches the perfection of meditative concentration that is empty of birth. The verse beginning "Your

understanding" shows the perfection of wisdom that, through effort joined with skillful means, has realized reality just as it is. The verse beginning "You do not wish to possess activity," together with the verse beginning "Since wisdom in the ultimate sense": these two verses show the perfection of skillful means in the form of an objection and its reply. Thus, by eleven verses, the seven perfections of those who have attained the grounds are taught.

The third chapter, on the phase of application of those who have attained the grounds.

Now, the exercise of mastery is fivefold: over the afflictions, over birth, over karma, over skillful means, and over bringing sentient beings to full maturity. Here, the verse beginning "Through the afflictions, awakening" teaches mastery over the afflictions. The verse beginning "Held by mindfulness and knowledge" gives its purpose. The verse beginning "Beings have become afflicted" shows mastery over birth. The verse beginning "Having destroyed, through the base of nothingness, the latent tendencies directed at objects" gives its purpose. The verse beginning "Former nonvirtuous deeds" shows mastery over karma. The verse beginning "Likewise, of the nonvirtuous" gives its purpose. The verse beginning "Like a mother, at times, not parted from compassion" shows mastery over skillful means. The verse beginning "Since, by various means" gives its purpose. The verse beginning "Some have entered the three awakenings, each according to their understanding" shows mastery over bringing sentient beings to full maturity. The verse beginning "Those who seek definitive liberation" gives its purpose. The verse beginning "Since you have cut off the births of beings, and" shows the cause brought to completion.

The fourth chapter, teaching the phase of the cause that shows the exercise of mastery.

The verse beginning "While the world was blinded by ignorance" teaches the generation of the gnosis of the path. The verse beginning "By many suns" shows the abandonment of the afflictions. The verse beginning "Incompatible with dwelling together" teaches the attainment of qualities. All these teach the praise of the Protector in the phase of the result.

The fifth chapter, teaching the phase of the result.

Now, the verse beginning "In the midst of the sky" properly teaches the turning of the wheel of Dharma. The verse beginning "This is pervasive suffering" teaches the intrinsic nature of teaching the Dharma. The verse beginning "As long as the light of the sun" properly teaches its long

endurance. Thus, with these three points, the phase of acting for the benefit of sentient beings is taught.

The sixth chapter, on the phase of acting for the benefit of sentient beings.

The last verse teaches the dedication of merit. Thus, the aspiration of the phases of the cause, the result, and acting for the benefit of sentient beings is not to pass completely beyond sorrow, for as long as may be.

The Commentary on the Praise of Infinite Qualities, composed by the great master Dignāga, is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The quoted words are the opening words of verses of the root hymn, the Praise of Infinite Qualities, which the commentary cites only in part; they are translated as the fragments they are. "The phase of mastery" renders dbang mdzad pa, the exercise of mastery or sovereignty (vaśitā), not empowerment. The four causes in the quoted verse (lineage, a virtuous friend, compassion, and not being turned back by suffering) correspond to the four causes of generating the mind of awakening taught in the Bodhisattvabhūmi. "Those who practice through conviction" renders mos pas spyod pa (adhimukticaryā), the stage of practice before the first bodhisattva ground.

- In the words quoted as "Through the afflictions, awakening," the Tibetan doubles the particle (nyon mongs bas pas); it is read as a single instrumental pas. "Meditative concentration that is empty of birth" (skye bas stong pa) probably refers to the bodhisattva's absorption that does not propel rebirth in the meditative heavens. In "the latent tendencies directed at objects," yul can (literally "having an object") is taken as describing the latent tendencies (anuśaya); the cited line is only a fragment, so its sense is uncertain. The three awakenings are those of the hearers, the solitary buddhas, and the buddhas.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.